2. Launch a national campaign of supplemental instruction targeted to the current level of learning of children (as opposed to teaching to the 'textbook') delivered by locally hired teacher assistants, with a goal of reaching minimum absolute standards of learning for all children. There is urgent need for a *mission-like* focus on delivering "universal functional literacy and numeracy" that allow children to *'read to learn'*. The evidence strongly supports scaling up supplemental instruction programmes using locally hired short-term teaching assistants that are targeted to the level of learning of the child, and the cost-effectiveness of this intervention also makes it easily scalable.
3. Pay urgent attention to issues of teacher governance including better monitoring and supervision as well as teacher performance measurement and management. A basic principle of effective management of organisations is to have clear goals and to reward employees for contributing towards meeting those goals. The extent to which the status quo does not do this effectively is highlighted in the large positive impacts found from even very modest improvements in the alignment of employee rewards with organisational goals. There can be potentially large returns of implementing these ideas in education and beyond.

The next decade will see the largest ever number of citizens in the school system at any point in Indian history (or future), and it is critical that this generation that represents the *demographic dividend* be equipped with the literacy and skills needed to participate fully in a rapidly modernising world. In a fiscally constrained environment, it is also imperative to use evidence to implement cost-effective policies that maximise the social returns on any given level of public investment. The growing body of high-quality research on primary education in the past decade provides opportunity for putting this principle into practice.

CAUTIONS TO PREPAREDNESS